

THE PUBLIC EXAMINATIONS (PREVENTION OF UNFAIR MEANS) AMENDMENT BILL, 2026, SET TO BE BROUGHT IN PARLIAMENT TODAY

PM sets up high-powered task force on exam reforms led by Nandan Nilekani

Minister Pralhad Joshi meets chief of NTA, top Education Ministry officials

Jatin Anand, Harikishan Sharma & Damini Nath
New Delhi, July 26

A DAY after the protest at Jantar Mantar over the NEET-UG paper leak was called off following Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation as Union Education Minister, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday announced a high-powered task force on exam reforms led by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani.

"Based on its report, the work to make our examination system more dependable will be done as soon as possible," the Prime Minister said in an Instagram video.

"For the future of students, the Government of India is continuously taking several steps. Those who played with the future of students are rotting in jails. We have established fast-track courts; in Parliament tomorrow, we are moving towards making a new law with tough provisions. We have to think of the future. That our education system becomes reliable, transparent and uses technology to the maximum," Modi said.

"Keeping all these things in mind, it has been decided to create a high-powered task force



PM Narendra Modi speaks in a video message posted on social media. VIDEO GRAB

underworld renowned technology expert Shri Nandan Nilekani, which will focus on examination reform," Modi said.

Nilekani had earlier headed the Aadhaar digital ID initiative under the UPA government. The new task force also includes: former ISRO chairman S Somnath, former IB Director Tapan Deka, IIT Madras director V Kamakoti, former Education Secretary Anita Karwal and retired IAS officer Amrit Lal Meena who has been included as a "logistics expert".

According to officials, the "multidisciplinary group of domain experts" will "help

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INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 27~07~2026
-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"
Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts
All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.
There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

THIRD SUCH INCIDENT IN ABOUT A WEEK

Another ship with 4 Indians targeted at Ukraine port, MEA issues advisory

Two confirmed safe, information awaited on other two: Indian Embassy

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 26

IN THE third such incident in about a week, a merchant vessel with four Indians aboard came under attack at Ukraine's Odesa port on Saturday. While two seafarers are safe, information on the other two is still awaited, the Indian Embassy in Kyiv said on Sunday.

With five deaths of Indian seafarers in the region since July 18, India on Sunday issued an advisory urging its citizens to carefully assess the security situation before taking up jobs in maritime zones witnessing conflicts, especially in the Black Sea area.

The latest attack on the *MV AGN Ragnar* occurred at the Port of Odesa, one of Ukraine's key Black Sea ports that has been a frequent target of missile and drone attacks since the outbreak of the Russia-Ukraine conflict in 2022.

"Embassy of India in Ukraine is closely monitoring the situation following the incident involving *MV AGN Rag-*

THE WORLD PAGE 14



RUSSIA, UKRAINE
REPORT CIVILIANS
KILLED IN STRIKES

nar, which was struck at the Port of Odesa on July 25," the Indian Embassy said in a post on social media. "Four Indian nationals were on board the vessel. As per the latest information, two have been confirmed safe, and information is awaited regarding the other two nationals," it said.

Saying that search and rescue operations were underway, the Indian Embassy said it was in constant touch with the concerned authorities to ascertain the status of the missing crew members and extend all

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EXPRESS special

Rajasthan farmers object to GI tag for Unjha (Gujarat) jeera and saunf

Harish Damodaran & Parimal A Dabhi
New Delhi, Ahmedabad, July 26

"JEERA KI kheti hum karte hain, Unjha toh sirf mandi hai (we cultivate jeera, Unjha is just a market)," says Champa Choudhary.

The 30-year-old is among Rajasthan's many *jeera* (cumin) and *saunf* (fennel) farmers aggrieved by the grant of Geographical Indication (GI) tags for 'Unjha Jeera' and 'Unjha Fennel'. The GIs have been registered in the name of the Agriculture Produce Market Committee (APMC) of Unjha, in Gujarat's Mehsana district.

"In Unjha, *jeera* is only traded, not produced. How can there be an Unjha Jeera when the crop isn't even grown in that area?," asks Choudhary, who farms jeera on 70 out of her 100 bigha (16.7 hectares) holding in Undoo village of Barmer district's Sheo tehsil.

Her statement is backed by

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Champa Choudhary at her jeera field in Undoo village of Barmer district in Rajasthan

E. EXPLAINED

A spicy battle

Unjha in Gujarat is synonymous with *jeera* and *saunf*, being India's biggest market for the two seed spices. Rajasthan's farmers who sell in this market, however, challenge a recent GI recognition to 'Unjha Jeera' and 'Unjha Fennel'. Unjha does not produce enough of these to deserve the tag, they say.

CRPF INQUIRY INTO CRACKDOWN ON PROTESTERS

RAF man fired 7 rounds from pellet gun, 5 hit protesters: Probe

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, July 26

THE CENTRAL Reserve Police Force (CRPF) is learnt to have found that a person from its Rapid Action Force (RAF), who was deployed in Connaught Place area during the July 20 protest march to Parliament, fired at least seven rounds from his pellet gun. Five rounds hit protesters, while two struck the ground, sources told *The Indian Express*.

As reported by *The Indian Express* earlier, the CRPF had initiated an inquiry into whether pellet guns were used



RAF personnel during the protest on July 20. GAJENDRA YADAV

by RAF personnel during the crackdown on protesters.

At least three persons were treated in hospitals for pellet

gun injuries sustained during the protest march — Irshad Sheikh, 25, who works in

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[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Task force

revamp the NTA examinations, especially (from the) technology perspective and structural reforms”.

In 2024, following an earlier NEET-UG leak, the Government had constituted a committee led by former ISRO chief K Radhakrishnan to overhaul the National Testing Agency (NTA) and reform the exam process. Its recommendations, including transitioning to a computer-based testing model, were in the process of being implemented.

The Government, meanwhile, is also all set to introduce an amendment Bill in Parliament on Monday to ensure swift punishment to those involved in exam paper leaks. The Union Cabinet had approved the changes to the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, on Friday.

The Prime Minister’s latest announcement came hours after Union Food Minister Pralhad Joshi, who has been given additional charge of the Education Ministry, held a series of review meetings with top officials in his new portfolio, including the NTA chief.

On Sunday, Joshi reached Kartavya Bhawan, which houses several ministries including the Education Ministry, at around 11.30 am and took charge of the new portfolio. The newly appointed School Education Secretary T K Anil Kumar briefed the Minister, followed by the outgoing Higher Education Secretary Vineet Joshi.

Both the secretaries made separate presentations about

various schemes and programmes under their charge. The Minister is learnt to have made several interventions during these meetings, including flagging the delay in availability of basic items like uniforms in schools.

Minister of State Jayant Chaudhary was present during the meetings while the other MoS Sukanta Majumdar was away.

Later, NTA Director General Abhishek Singh briefed the Minister about the functions and responsibilities of the agency. The NTA is the nodal autonomous body that conducts entrance tests to higher educational institutions, such as NEET-UG. The Sunday Express reported that the NTA had “terminated the services” of 47 officials following the NEET-UG paper leak.

Joshi’s meetings come at a time when 41 questions are listed for the Education Ministry in Parliament. House records show there is no direct question on the NEET-UG leak but the YSRCP has raised alleged irregularities in the teacher recruitment examination in Andhra Pradesh, which includes a reference to exam paper leaks.

In their starred question, to which the Minister has to provide an oral reply if supplementary questions are raised, YSRCP MPs PV Midhun Reddy and Dr Gumma Thanuja Rani have asked whether the Government has taken cognizance of reports alleging irregularities in the teacher recruitment exam in Andhra Pradesh, including allegations relating to question paper security, recruitment procedures and sports quota appointments.

Gujarat: Mehsana, Patan, Banaskantha, Sabarkantha, Aravalli, Kheda, Gandhinagar, Ahmedabad, Surendranagar, Morbi and Kutch.

Dinesh Patel, chairman of the Unjha APMC, defends the GI tags: “Unjha region is the pioneer in *jeera* cultivation. The acreage may have come down, with people taking its seeds for growing in other places and even China. But since the production originated here, only the crop in this geography, and not China, can be called Unjha Jeera.”

Regarding ‘Unjha Fennel’, Patel affirms that “the taste of our *saunf* is completely different”. Moreover, the GI certificates for both products were obtained after submission of “more than 1,000 pages of documents containing scientific evidence, analysis, etc,” he says. The applications for the GIs were made on June 24, 2024, with authentication letters from the Gujarat government’s directorate of horticulture, Sardarkrushinagar Dantiwada Agricultural University at Banaskantha and the Entrepreneurship Development Institute of India, Ahmedabad.

However, Bhagirath Choudhary, founder-director of the Jodhpur-based South Asia Biotechnology Centre, contends that the GI applications for ‘Unjha Jeera’ and ‘Unjha Fennel’ have predominantly relied on Unjha’s reputation as a premier spices aggregation, grading and trading centre. “GI protection should be based on a product’s unique quality and other attributes linked to a place or region where it is produced, as opposed to marketed,” he says.

tificate issued on March 28 by the Geographical Indication Registry in Chennai, is not limited to Mehsana. It also covers Banaskantha, Patan, Ahmedabad, Surendranagar, Botad, Morbi, Jamnagar, Rajkot, Amreli, Gir Somnath, Junagadh, Porbandar, Devbhumi Dwarka and Kutch districts of Gujarat.

A similar apprehension is voiced by Rajasthan’s saunf farmers. Ishaq Ali grows the seed spice on nine out of his 10-hectare land in Kachholi village of Sirohi district’s Pindwara tehsil. He, too, sells half of his 22-23 tonnes produce in the Unjha APMC that is roughly 130 km away.

The ‘Abu Saunf-440’ variety developed by him — registered as a “farmers’ variety” under the Protection of Plant Varieties and Farmers’ Rights Act — is cultivated in over 5,000 hectares area of Sirohi district in the foothills of Mount Abu.

“I get a premium for my bold and lustrous green-seeded *saunf* variety having unique aroma. It fetches Rs 450-500 per kg in online sales and Rs 300-400 in Unjha, whereas the regular *saunf* there is sold at Rs 100-200,” claims Ali.

The 55-year-old fears that the GI tag for ‘Unjha Fennel’ will undermine the *saunf* grown in Rajasthan, including the speciality variety bred by him through field-level knowledge and selection: “How can you register a GI in the name of an APMC?”

The geographical area of cultivation for which the ‘Unjha Fennel’ GI certificate of registration was given on March 28, again, covers several districts of

GI tag

the Gujarat government’s data, showing the area under jeera in Mehsana district at a mere 174 hectares (out of the state’s total 4,76,537 hectares) and production at 149 tonnes (out of 4,07,629 tonnes) during 2024-25.

For Choudhary — she is also a director of the Maru Laxmi Cumin Farmers Producer Company — Unjha is a preferred market despite it being some 370 km from her village: “The APMCs within Rajasthan are closer, like Jodhpur (165 km) and Merta (290 km). But we don’t get good rates there, unlike in Unjha that has more buyers, including major exporters and trading firms”.

Choudhary’s cooperative pooled about 2,000 tonnes of jeera from its 400 women farmer-members during the 2025-26 crop season (October-March). Of that, 500 tonnes was sold as IPM (integrated pest management)-quality jeera to the Aluva (Kerala)-based spices processor AVT McCormick Ingredients Pvt Ltd at Rs 230 per kg. The balance 1,500 tonnes was sold in the Unjha APMC at Rs 180-200/kg. At an average Rs 210/kg rate, the cooperative recorded a turnover of Rs 42 crore.

“The GI tag for Unjha Jeera will be used by traders at the APMC to beat down our prices. They will paint our *jeera* as inferior and their produce as premium,” she alleges.

Interestingly, the notified geographical area for ‘Unjha Jeera’, as per the registration cer-

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The MPs have also asked the Education Minister whether the Government proposes to issue any advisory or framework to states to strengthen examination security, prevent paper leaks and ensure transparency and accountability during recruitment in large-scale public examinations.

Delimitation, women’s quota

Sources said that beyond education reforms, the Government is also focused on introducing at the earliest the legislative package on operationalising the women’s reservation law and expanding the strength of Parliament and state legislatures.

A senior functionary said the focus remains on women’s quota law and delimitation. “Our priority is to implement women’s reservation as the Prime Minister has promised,” the functionary said when asked if the protests had derailed these plans.

If the Bills are not introduced during the ongoing Monsoon Session, it would have to be brought during the Winter Session later this year as the Constitution freezes the readjustment of seats only until the first Census conducted after 2026. With the 2027 Census expected to be that Census, the constitutional bar on fresh delimitation would cease thereafter.

It would be “business as usual” in Parliament on Monday, said another senior Government functionary. “He (Pradhan) had nothing to do with the (NEET-UGC) paper leak. He has taken moral responsibility and stepped down. That is all there is to it. This has nothing to do with the govern-

ment’s legislative agenda.”

“What happened beyond the precincts of the Parliament, and was taken to its logical conclusion by a slew of measures aimed at regaining the trust of the youth, is different from the legislative agenda which is part of the Government’s commitment,” said a BJP source.

“If anything, the successful redress of the Gen Z and youth protesters’ concerns not just through official assurances but concrete governmental and administrative measures such as the Cabinet’s nod to the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, and the complete restructuring of the NTA, along with two other significant demands, has only underlined the Government’s strong foundation among the people including the youth,” the source asserted.

A senior BJP leader said the Government’s “reconciliatory approach”, with Prime Minister Modi as its face, to a youth-driven movement that had the potential of “snowballing into a negative campaign” had helped its chances of mustering the two-thirds majority required to approve amendments to the Constitution.

The BJP-led NDA was “more than prepared” to take on the Opposition in a debate on exam paper leaks, the BJP functionary said. “For parties which are on the fence regarding supporting the NDA, the Government’s swift and satisfactory response (to youth protests) is seen to have provided an opportunity to exhibit issue-based support to be on the right side of historic legislation such as the women’s reservation law,” the leader contended.

Pellet gun

Gurgaon; Sahil Lochab, 19, a Delhi University student, and a 28-year-old journalist with Outlook magazine.

After examining log entries made by RAF personnel, it emerged that a total of seven pellet rounds had been fired by one RAF person in Connaught Place, said a source. “Five of the rounds hit the protesters and two hit the ground. The rounds were fired after protesters attacked security personnel and started pelting stones,” the source said.

When contacted, DG (CRPF) Gyanendra Pratap Singh reiterated his earlier statement: “Now, since the agitation has been called off, and assembled people have dispersed, we would make a professional post-event assessment, like we do after every major assignment, and then let you know the view of the Force headquarter.” Queries sent to RAF Inspector General Seema Dhundhia and the CRPF spokesperson did not elicit any response.

On Sunday, *The Indian Express* reported that Dhundhia was learnt to have told personnel that the “force gradient”

adopted for crowd control during the July 20 protest march was not in accordance with prescribed standards and RAF training. The observation came after an internal review flagged serious operational lapses.

In the context of policing, a force gradient refers to the different levels of force that police may use, depending on the threat or resistance they face.

Dhundhia held a video conference on July 22 with company commanders and commandants deployed in Delhi. “The meeting reviewed the role, deployment and conduct of RAF personnel during the protest at Jantar Mantar and the Sansad Chalo march. A series of corrective measures were laid down for future law and order duties,” a source said.

“Officers were instructed that force must be used only to the extent necessary, and in a judicious, fair, balanced and sensitive manner. They were also told that before using force, personnel should issue necessary warnings and follow graded crowd-control measures such as lathi charge, tear smoke and other approved methods, depending on the situation,” the source said.

4 Indians

possible assistance.

“Since April, there has been an increase in the number of such incidents on commercial vessels, which has also resulted in the loss of five Indian lives,” the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said in an advisory issued on Sunday.

On July 18, an Indian seafarer was killed in an attack on a ship while it was reportedly transiting Russian territorial waters in the Black Sea. A day later, four Indian seafarers were among 10 killed in an attack on a commercial vessel off the coast of Ukraine.

New Delhi had summoned the Russian Charge d’Affaires following the deaths of four Indians in the strike on the MV Golden Leo on July 19. While Moscow indicated that the ship was targeted for carrying military supplies for Ukraine, India countered that it was carrying grain as cargo. External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar also raised the issue with Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov.

“Indian nationals intending to undertake employment on commercial vessels operating in or transiting the conflict-affected region are advised to carefully as-

sess the prevailing security risks before accepting such assignments,” the MEA said in its advisory on Sunday.

It said the situation in and around the Black Sea and adjoining maritime areas “remains highly volatile due to the ongoing conflict.” “Commercial vessels operating in or transiting these waters are facing significant security risks, including missile and drone attacks,” it said.

It appealed to those seeking employment to obtain “comprehensive information from employers’ recruitment agencies and ship operators regarding the vessel’s intended route, ports of call, security arrangements, insurance coverage, and emergency response procedures.”

“Ensure that the terms of employment comply with applicable international maritime standards and provide adequate provisions for medical care, evacuation, repatriation, and compensation in the event of an emergency,” the MEA said.

It also asked them to keep their family members informed of their itinerary and maintain regular contact. “Indian nationals requiring consular assistance are advised to contact the Embassy of India or Consulates in the region,” the MEA said.

Months after HC rap, Govt appoints heads for DCW, minorities panel

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 26

MONTHS AFTER being pulled up by the Delhi High Court over long-standing vacancies, the Delhi government has appointed chairpersons and members to women and minority rights watchdogs in the Capital.

The Chief Minister's Office on Sunday said Lata Gupta has been appointed the Chairperson of the Delhi Commission for Women (DCW), with Shyam Bala, Malti Verma, Lata Sodhi, Sanrika Sharma Jha and Renu Bhalla as its members. Nirmal Jain has been appointed the Chairperson of the Delhi Minorities Commission (DMC), while Kuldeep Singh and Mohammad Haroon were nominated as members.

The High Court had pulled up the government five months ago for not appointing a chairperson and members to the DCW, which has not had a chief after the tenure of its previous chief, Swati Maliwal, ended in January 2024 following her nomination to the Rajya Sabha.

The DMC has also not had a head or members since August 2023. The court had in April also sought an explanation from the government for prolonged delay in the appointments at DMC.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the commissions were "not merely statutory bodies but important platforms that will strengthen public trust and amplify the voices of the weaker and disadvantaged sections of society".

According to the government, this is a significant decision aimed at strengthening the protection of women's rights, promoting their empowerment, and ensuring the welfare of minority communities as well as protection of their constitutional rights.

Lata Gupta is a senior BJP



Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta with newly-appointed members. EXPRESS

leader who began her public life in student politics and has served as the Delhi BJP vice-president, former Shahdara district president and former general secretary of the party's women's wing. She was a municipal councillor from Shakarpur (2007-12) and Pandav Nagar (2012-17) wards, and became the first woman chairperson of the Standing Committee of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi.

Jain has served as the Mayor of the East Delhi Municipal Corporation in 2020-21.

He has been a councillor from Shahdara, chaired the MCD's Standing Committee on appointments and discipline in 2009 and was the Leader of House in EDMC from 2018 to 2020.

The DCW was created under the Delhi Commission for Women Act, 1994, with the aim of investigating and examining all matters relating to the safeguards provided to women as per the Constitution and other laws, states its website. The DMC was set up under the Delhi Minorities Commission Act, 1999, to safeguard the rights and interests of the minority communities in Delhi.

Meet the six experts in the high-powered task force



Nandan Nilekani

The co-founder and chairman of Infosys Technologies Limited, Nilekani was the founding chairman of the UIDAI in the rank of a Cabinet Minister from 2009-2014. In January 2023, he was appointed the co-chair of the “G20 Task Force on Digital Public Infrastructure for Economic Transformation, Financial Inclusion, and Development”.

Nilekani was also the chairman of the Technology Advisory Group for Unique Projects (TAGUP), established by the government in 2010, that influenced the IT system for large-scale public projects, including GST. Born in Bengaluru, Nilekani received his Bachelor's degree from IIT, Bombay.



Amrit Lal Meena

A retired Bihar-cadre IAS officer (1989 batch), Meena served as Chief Secretary of Bihar from August 2024 to August 2025. He was earlier the Secretary in the Coal Ministry, and before that he held the charge of Special Secretary (Logistics), DPIT. In the six-member high-powered task force on examination reforms, he has been appointed as the Logistics Expert. He holds a BTech in electrical engineering.



Anita Karwal

She was India's Education Secretary between 2020 and her retirement in 2022. Before that, Karwal was the chairperson of the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE). After her retirement, she was appointed as the chairperson of Gujarat Real Estate Regulatory Authority.

Karwal was closely involved with the development of the government's National Education Policy 2020. She is a retired Gujarat cadre IAS officer (1988-batch).



S Somanath

He served as ISRO chairperson between 2022 and 2025. It was under his leadership that India achieved the successful landing of Chandrayaan-3 on the Moon's South Pole. He was also at the helm of the space agency when the small satellite launch vehicle was operationalised, and its heaviest launch vehicle LVM3 was adapted for launching in different types of orbit.

Earlier, as a specialist in propulsion science, Somanath worked on the development of the LVM3 vehicle that carried both Chandrayaan-2 and 3. He joined the Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre in 1985.



Dr V Kamakoti

He is the director of IIT Madras, a role he assumed in 2022. Kamakoti specialises in computer architecture, security and artificial intelligence. He is known for leading the research team that developed India's first indigenous microprocessor 'Shakti', which can be used in mobile computing devices and networking systems. He was the chairman of the Artificial Intelligence Task Force constituted by the Ministry of Commerce and Industry. Kamakoti did his PhD from IIT Madras in 1995 and then joined the institute as an assistant professor in 2001.



Tapan Deka

A 1988-batch IPS officer of the Himachal cadre, he served as the IB chief for four years. Dekka is credited with strengthening intelligence coordination through the modernisation of the Multi Agency Centre, enhancing intelligence-sharing between central and state agencies, and playing a key role in generating actionable intelligence for counter-terrorism and anti-Maoist operations. Earlier, he spent over a decade in the IB's Operations branch, overseeing counter-terrorism efforts against the Indian Mujahideen and the Islamic State. **ENS**

Rajnath: Our intention clear, talks with Pak only on PoK

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, July 26

DEFENCE MINISTER Rajnath Singh said on Sunday that no talks with Pakistan are in the offing, and that even if there were to be talks, they would only be about Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK).

“Our intention is clear. There will be no talks with Pakistan,” Singh said in his speech on the occasion of Kargil Vijay Diwas at the Kargil War Memorial in Dras. “If talks happen, they will happen only regarding PoK, which is a part of India illegally occupied by Pakistan,” he said.

Twenty-seven years after the Indian Army forced Pakistan to withdraw from the Kargil peaks it had occupied, the Defence Minister warned the neighbouring country against any “misadventure”.

“India will respond harshly and with the same strategic approach in case of a misadventure by Pakistan,” Singh said, referring to last year’s Operation Sindoor, in which Indian forces struck terrorist targets in Pakistan and PoK in response to the Pahalgam terror attack. “I want to give a clear message. Every nefarious act aimed at undermining India’s sovereignty will face the same fate,” he added.

Accusing Pakistan of institutionalising terrorism as a state policy, Singh said that



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh pays tribute to fallen soldiers on the occasion of the 27th Kargil Vijay Diwas at Dras in Ladakh on Sunday. PTI

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while India is progressing through innovation and technology, Pakistan continues to promote terrorism, radicalisation and infiltration.

‘Our paths are different’

“India is giving software to the world, while Pakistan is giving (terrorist) sleeper cells to the world. India is building data centres and Pakistan is building radical centres. India is connecting the world through UPI, while Pakistan is connecting terrorism through hawala. In other words, our paths are different...,” he said, adding,

“India is building a start-up ecosystem and Pakistan is building a terror ecosystem. India is making semiconductors while Pakistan is preparing suicide bombers. India is known for space missions and Pakistan is running proxy missions. India is sending satellites into space while Pakistan is still engaged in sending terrorists across borders.”

The Defence Minister also said India would no longer distinguish between terrorists and their support structure.

“Pakistan has now made terrorism a part of its government policy. The distinction between the military and mili-

itants there has been erased. The Army there not only provides protection to terrorist organisations but also works hand in hand with them,” he said. “Therefore, during Operation Sindoor itself, we made it clear that India would no longer see terrorists and the governments that nurture them as separate.”

Paying tribute to the soldiers killed during the Kargil war, the Defence Minister said that Kargil was not just a military victory but also a diplomatic victory for India and a defining moment that showcased “courage, determination and sacrifices” of the soldiers.

EXPRESS special

Amid protests & clashes, legislative assembly of PoK heads to polls today

Divya A
New Delhi, July 26

AMID VIOLENT protests and clashes that have been going on for several weeks now, the legislative assembly of Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) will head to election on Monday. The polls will be held in three phases, ending August 10, authorities have announced.

While unrest has been brewing in PoK for more than a year, the spate of violent clashes in recent weeks — in the run-up to elections — has left at least 20 people dead at the hands of security personnel, and several others injured, according to news agency PTI.

Primarily led by civil society coalition Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC), now banned by the Pakistan government, the latest spate of demonstrations, sources said, reflect the growing anger over economic hardship, political disenfranchisement and increasing restrictions on civil liberties.

A source in the security establishment said, “Widespread public anger is directed at the 12 legislative assembly seats reserved for non-residents — a manipulative tactic used by the federal government to plant loyalists and dilute genuine local representation.”

Sources said that is one of the key reasons why the party ruling Islamabad usually wins PoK elections — be it Pakistan People’s Party in 2011, Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz in 2016 or Imran Khan’s Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf in 2021.

Of the 53 seats in the legis-



The spate of violent clashes in recent weeks has left at least 20 people dead at the hands of security personnel in PoK. FILE

lative assembly of PoK, eight are reserved for women, technocrats and clerics. Of the remaining 45, 12 are reserved for migrants settled in different parts of Pakistan. It is these 12 seats that have been a bone of contention with locals demanding that this reservation be abolished.

‘Integral part of India’

According to sources closely monitoring developments in the area, the ongoing unrest was triggered by “a total collapse of local governance, with authorities imposing an economic blockade that has caused critical shortages of subsidised wheat and essential medicines”.

They say that the anger is also driven by what is called “economic extraction”. “The dams in PoK generate power far beyond the local demand of about 400 MW, yet residents face up to 15-20 hours of load shedding and pay tariffs several times the cost of generation,” they added.

The protesters’ 38-point charter directly targets the alleged financial corruption and unchecked privileges of the ruling elite. The source also pegged the number of lives lost to indiscriminate firing by security forces on peaceful protesters at 150.

New Delhi maintains that PoK is an integral part of India under illegal occupation. The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said that the recent public unrest is the direct result of “Islamabad’s decades-long systemic economic exploitation, denial of fundamental rights, and administrative oppression”.

On July 14, MEA Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said, “The ongoing protests in Pakistan-occupied Jammu & Kashmir are a direct consequence, and indeed evidence, of decades of exploitation, the denial of fundamental rights, and administrative repression under Pakistan’s illegal and forcible occupation of the region.”

“Instead of addressing the legitimate grievances of the local population, the authorities there have resorted to excessive police brutality,” he said, adding that this has included action against vulnerable civilians, including women and children. “We expect the international community to hold Pakistan accountable for these grave human rights abuses,” Jaiswal added.

On July 17, the Office of the United Nations’ Human Rights Commissioner also took note of the situation, calling for “prompt, thorough and impartial investigations into all deaths that have occurred due to the unrest”.

Fresh escalation

The latest wave of protests was triggered after the Pakistani government banned JAAC under anti-terrorism laws.

Following the ban, JAAC leader Sardar Aman Khan appealed for assistance from India. “We need India’s help. There is a shortage of rations...,” Khan was seen saying in a video that has been widely shared on social media.

Sources said that Pakistan is “weaponising anti-terror laws to crush civil liberties, banning the JAAC and arbitrarily arresting over 600 civil rights activists and local leaders”.

Meanwhile, sources said that Pakistan Army Chief Asim Munir is marketing a “theoretical \$6 trillion mineral dream” resting heavily on Gilgit-Baltistan, where an army-linked firm was caught extracting ore without local approval in 2025.

As monsoon revives, ‘intense’ rain likely to hit over 10 states

Express News Service
Bengaluru, July 26

AFTER A long lull, the South-west Monsoon has shown signs of revival.

Over 10 states, including Odisha and West Bengal, are bracing for very heavy rain spells, predicted until Monday.

“Intense rain” warning has been issued till July 30 over Gangetic West Bengal, Jharkhand, Bihar, Chhattisgarh and the eastern and western regions of Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh.

Extremely heavy rain will continue in coastal Odisha and West Bengal till Monday. The 24-hour rainfall recorded over

Jagatsinghpur on Sunday was 330 mm. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) on Sunday said a depression had formed in the north Bay of Bengal region, off the Odisha coast.

According to the Met office, this system was located about 130 km south-southeast of Sagar Island and 140 km south-east of Digha in West Bengal and about 170 km east of Chandbali and 180 km east-southeast of Balasore in Odisha.

“It is very likely to move northwestwards, intensify further into a deep depression during the next 24 hours. It will cross north Odisha and West Bengal coasts, between Paradip and Sagar islands, around fore-

noon or noon on Monday,” the IMD said.

“Extreme heavy” rainfall is expected in Sundargarh, Keonjhar, and Mayurbhanj districts on Monday. The IMD has issued a ‘red alert’ (take action) for these districts.

The weather office has advised fishermen not to venture into the sea along and off the Odisha coast till July 29. Local administrations have ordered schools to remain closed in Jagatsinghpur and Mayurbhanj districts on Monday.

Jammu and Kashmir, Haryana, Punjab, Delhi and most of northeast India regions will experience intermittent rain till August 1.



A flooded stretch on Ahmedabad-Rajkot national highway on Sunday. REUTERS

• GEOPOLITICS

Indus Waters Treaty: India’s plans, Pakistan’s protests



SHUBHAJIT ROY

PAKISTAN HAS been targeting India in recent weeks over the Indus Waters Treaty (IWT), which New Delhi placed in abeyance after the Pahalgam terror attack last April. Pakistan’s Defence Minister Khawaja Asif recently said his country would not hesitate to go to war for its water security. The Indian government’s argument, that “blood and water cannot flow together”, has at times been perceived to be directed at its domestic political constituency. That weakens its argument in front of the global audience, which often is sympathetic to Pakistan portraying itself as the lower riparian victim.

Pakistan’s actions

India maintains it has honoured the treaty amid wars, military crises, terror attacks and prolonged periods of bilateral hostility as Pakistan pursued a policy of cross-border terrorism. According to New Delhi, such treaties cannot remain insulated from persistent acts of hostility. India feels that Pakistan’s conduct reflects a pattern of obstruction. Virtually every Indian project on the Western Rivers (meant for Pakistan’s use) — irrespective of its size, storage capacity or technical design — has been objected to by Pakistan. Indian officials argue that the treaty’s dispute resolution provisions, intended as an exceptional mechanism to resolve genuine differences, have been converted into instruments for delaying Indian projects.

New hydrological realities

The IWT reflects the technological and hydrological realities of the late 1950s. More than 60 years later, India’s population has increased several-fold, resulting in higher demand for drinking water, irrigation, industry and urban development needs. States dependent upon the Indus Basin — including Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan — face increasing water stress and developmental requirements that could not have been envisaged when the Treaty was signed.

The Indus Basin

India also faces a serious challenge of declining groundwater levels, particularly



The Salal dam on the Chenab. Pakistan had objected to it. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS Real Creator IAS Edition https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F

in Punjab and Haryana, making greater utilisation of available surface water an urgent national priority.

At the same time, the hydrological regime has evolved, with reduced availability in the Eastern Rivers (for India’s use), while flows in the Western Rivers have not experienced a comparable decline. Climate change has altered basin dynamics through greater hydrological variability, increasing the need for flood moderation, drought resilience, storage optimisation and adaptive operations. Engineering practices have undergone a profound transformation since 1960. Modern dam safety and sustainability require low-level outlets, drawdown flushing, gated spillways, advanced sediment management and flexible reservoir operations. These technologies were either unavailable or not widely recognised when the treaty was drafted.

India’s commitments towards clean energy transition and climate goals require efficient development of hydropower infrastructure using state-of-the-art engineering practices, rather than technologies frozen in the engineering standards of the 1950s.

The IWT imposes extensive obligations on India concerning project design, storage limits, spillway configuration, operational procedures and advance information. While Pakistan has built hydropower projects on its rivers, it objects to similar initiatives by India.

Dividing a river system

The Indus Waters Treaty divides the six rivers of the Indus system, giving India control of the Eastern Rivers (Ravi, Beas, and Sutlej), and Pakistan the Western Rivers (Indus, Jhelum, and Chenab).

Sections within India have long held that the IWT is one of the most generous water-sharing arrangements ever accepted by an upper riparian state.

Since the treaty was put in abeyance, Pakistan has been targeting India on international fora for ‘treating a lower riparian state unfairly’

and established operational practices of run-of-the-river hydropower projects. River flows at downstream locations such as Marala are influenced by seasonal snowmelt in the Himalayas. Variations in winter snowfall, delayed melting, or cooler spring temperatures naturally affect early-season discharge levels. Such fluctuations cannot, by themselves, be interpreted as evidence of deliberate interference. Temporary fluctuations in downstream river flows during sediment flushing or maintenance operations are normal, regulated engineering phenomena observed in reservoir operations across the world.

What India may now be looking at

Utilising waters: India is expediting projects designed to prevent the avoidable wastage of waters allocated to it. A key priority will be the accelerated development of hydropower projects on the Chenab basin. These are critical for India’s clean energy transition, grid stability and regional development.

Major projects under implementation include the 1,856 MW Sawalkot Hydroelectric Project, the 1,000 MW Pakal Dul Project, the 850 MW Ratle Project, the 624 MW Kiru Project and the 540 MW Kwar Project.

The Ujh Multipurpose Project, on a tributary of the Ravi, will enable the storage and productive utilisation of waters that presently flow unutilised across the International Boundary while simultaneously providing irrigation, drinking water, flood moderation and hydropower benefits to Jammu & Kashmir and other states.

Flushing reservoirs: India will also restore the efficiency and sustainability of existing hydropower projects through modern reservoir and sediment management practices. For decades, essential maintenance measures such as sediment flushing and operation of low-level outlets were either delayed or constrained because of persistent objections from Pakistan, despite these being internationally accepted engineering practices.

The Salal Hydroelectric Project illustrates the consequences of such restrictions. Originally designed with a gross storage capacity of about 284 million cubic metres (MCM), the project had to plug its low-level sediment outlets following Pakistan’s objections, depriving the reservoir of its primary sediment management mechanism. As a result, the reservoir silted up within a few years of commissioning, reducing its effective storage.

• CLIMATE

Why Assam is experiencing unprecedented flooding this year

Sukrita Baruah Guwahati, July 26



Houses and villages submerged in Sivasagar, Assam. ANI

AT LEAST 66 lives lost in around a week, close to seven lakh people affected, and the government struggling to reach thousands of people — Assam is in the grip of an unprecedented wave of floods.

The people who live in the three most affected districts — the Upper Assam districts of Sivasagar, Charaideo, and Jorhat — say they have never experienced such flooding in their lifetimes.

Extent of devastation

Floodwaters had reached critical levels on July 19 and began spreading rapidly. At the height of the floods, over 7 lakh people were affected and 1.15 lakh had moved to relief camps. With the floodwaters gradually receding, the total population affected has dropped slightly to 6.54 lakh across 810 villages in 10 districts on Saturday, according to the Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA). Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said Friday that the government had been

unable to reach parts of Sivasagar district even after water levels had come down. This, he said, was because of the receding floodwaters leaving behind layers of sediment several feet high.

Through the course of the week, the rivers Dikhow, Dhansiri, the Disang and the Janji and Darika — Brahmaputra tributaries that flow through this belt — have flowed above their “danger levels”.

Extreme weather events

The Assam government had initially at-

Rising trend

- High intensity rainfall events can cause damage and floods.
- Experts agree that with climate change, such events are becoming more frequent.

tributed the flooding to a “cloudburst” in Mon in Nagaland on July 19, which is upstream to these tributaries.

A scientist at the Meteorological Centre Kohima, however, told *The Indian Express* that the area had not experienced a cloudburst (defined as rainfall exceeding 100 mm within one hour) but rather heavy rainfall of 137 mm over 8 to 9 hours on that day. This had also triggered multiple landslides in Mon, leaving nine people dead.

Sarma said Friday that the rainfall received over the course of July 18 and 19 in three Nagaland districts and Assam’s Charaideo district was well over “normal levels”. He said the speed at which water levels rose because of this was “unprecedented”, and that the already swollen Brahmaputra hindered the drainage of tributaries into it.

Experts agree that with climate change, high intensity rainfall events of over 50 or 100 mm in one day, which cause damage and floods, are becoming more frequent, and will increase in coming years.

Combination of factors

Dhrubajyoti Saharia, professor of

geography at Gauhati University who is studying the current wave of floods, said there has indeed been excessive rainfall.

“There is a mix of rainfall and anthropogenic factors. One contributing factor can be that in satellite images, we have seen excessive excavation on the river valley sides... likely because of mining. (This) would mean a large amount of mud flowing down, which reduces the river carrying capacity,” he said. Nayan Sharma, retired professor from IIT Roorkee specialising in water resources and river engineering, said that deforestation is one of several contributing factors and “100% afforestation” was needed in watershed areas.

“If the ground is barren, the water doesn’t have enough time to percolate and it moves downhill very fast and carries a lot of silt. Which is what we’re seeing, with a rapid loss of forest cover. This excess silt then raises the river bed and reduces carrying capacity,” he said.

According to him, more effective forecasting using global precipitation monitoring systems would not make the scale of destruction “inevitable”.

• ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

How quantum computing and AI can help trigger a better immune response



EXPERT EXPLAINS

TIMOTHY PATRICK JENKINS

ASSOCIATE PROFESSOR OF BIOTECHNOLOGY, TECHNICAL UNIVERSITY OF DENMARK

COULD THE next breakthrough in cancer treatment come from combining artificial intelligence (AI) with quantum computing? Researchers at the Technical University of Denmark (DTU) have taken an early step by using a photonic quantum computer to improve how an AI model designs peptides, which help the body’s immune system recognise diseased or infected cells.

A quantum computer differs from a normal or classical computer primarily in the way it is built and operates. While the latter

uses bits (basic unit of classical information) that are either 0 or 1, a quantum computer uses qubits (fundamental unit of quantum information) that can be both at the same time. A photonic quantum computer uses individual light particles, or photons, as qubits to encode and process information.

The DTU’s proof-of-concept study, awaiting peer review, confirmed through laboratory tests that the AI-designed peptides could successfully bind to human leukocyte antigen (HLA) molecules present on a cell’s surface — a critical first step in triggering an immune response.

What are peptides, and why is designing them hard?

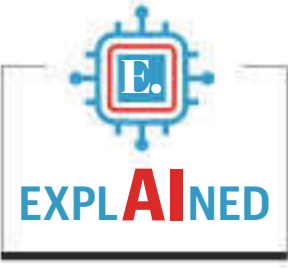
Peptides are short chains of amino acids, the building blocks of proteins. In im-

munology, they matter because cells display peptides on their surface, allowing your immune system to inspect them and decide what is healthy and what is foreign. Many vaccines work by showing the immune system the right peptide and training it to respond. The HLA proteins, sitting on the surface of almost all your cells, are the immune molecules. They act like a display shelf, grabbing short peptides from inside the cell and holding them up on the surface so patrolling immune cells can inspect them. A peptide only gets shown to the immune system if it can bind and sit stably in the groove of an HLA molecule.

So binding is the entry ticket: no binding, no display, no immune recognition. Designing a peptide that binds a particular HLA is the first step in developing such vaccines or immune therapies.

The difficulty then is the sheer size of the

search space. Even for a short peptide, there are hundreds of billions of possible sequences, and only a tiny fraction binds well to any given person’s HLA molecules. Finding those needles in that haystack, especially for immune types that are poorly represented in existing data, is hard. The AI does the actual design work: it learns the patterns of real immune-binding peptides and proposes new ones. Every such model needs a random starting point for each new design. Normally, that’s a simple, standard distribution from a classical computer. We replaced it with samples from a photonic quantum processor, which produces a fundamentally different, more richly correlated kind of randomness that is hard to reproduce on a classical machine.



A weekly column decoding AI’s new frontiers, how they shape the world and our place in it

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD.RGf9mJmZg1 So the quantum computer didn’t replace the AI; it changed the raw material the AI starts from. Handing the model these structured, correlated starting points appears to push it to explore a wider, less obvious range of designs, rather than converging on familiar designs. That seems to matter most for the harder, understudied immune types where there is little data to guide it.

Why do the gains for data-poor HLA types matter?

HLA genes are among the most variable in the human genome. There are thousands of versions, and you inherit your particular set from your parents.

Versions may differ between individuals and between populations, so two people can display quite different peptides from the very same virus. This partly explains why a given infection or vaccine can provoke a stronger response in some people than others. It’s also why some HLA types are well-studied and data-rich while others, often those more common in underrepre-

sented populations, have far less data. Current tools work well for common HLA types. That means people with less-studied immune profiles are often less well served by AI-driven design. In our work, the quantum-derived starting distribution performed best for these rarer HLA types.

Why was lab validation important?

Prediction tools are least reliable for the rare immune types we cared about most, so a purely computational result would not have been convincing. We synthesised the top quantum-designed peptides and tested in the lab whether they actually bind well to HLA molecules. Across all three HLA types tested, the peptides bound their targets, with nearly all succeeding for two HLA types and about three-quarters for the most difficult one, whose unusual chemistry makes it challenging for existing predictors. Validation is what separates a real demonstration from an interesting simulation.

FULL INTERVIEW ON INDIANEXPRESS.COM/EXPLAINED



For antibiotics, the right dose is restraint

INDIA'S DEPENDENCE on antibiotics as a convenient cure-all for routine illnesses has reached an inflection point. A global study published in *The Lancet Public Health* has highlighted a worrying imbalance in the country's antibiotic use: An over-reliance on stronger medicines even as safer first-line medicines remain underused. The World Health Organisation classifies antibiotics into three categories — "access" drugs, which are recommended as first-line treatments for common infections; "watch" drugs, which are broader-spectrum medicines that should be reserved for specific situations; and "reserve" drugs, intended as a last line of defence against highly resistant infections. The study estimates India's optimal antibiotic use at 9.9 to 14.7 defined daily doses per 1,000 people per day. Actual use, however, stands much higher at 18.3 doses, with "watch" antibiotics at 9.3 doses against a recommended 6 doses. "Access" antibiotics, at 4.5 doses, fall well short of what is needed.

The preference for "watch" drugs reveals the challenge in how antibiotics are understood, prescribed and consumed. A prescription for a broad-spectrum antibiotic can often feel like reassurance both to a patient seeking quick recovery and to a doctor working in an overstretched healthcare system. But each unnecessary dose narrows the options available for future infections. At the same time, the underuse of "reserve" antibiotics in genuinely resistant cases points to another systemic failure: Ensuring that the right medicine reaches the right patient at the right moment. Fragmented healthcare delivery, poor diagnostic access, and — beyond the clinic — the liberal use of antibiotics in livestock and agriculture, all feed India's rising burden of antimicrobial resistance, where bacteria become resistant to common drugs and infections become more difficult and expensive to treat.

Given the country's burden of infectious disease, antibiotics will remain indispensable. Addressing the problem must, thus, begin with replacing quick-fix prescriptions with evidence-based care. National Action Plan on Antimicrobial Resistance 2.0 (2025–2029) places antimicrobial stewardship at the heart of the response, seeking to curb inappropriate usage across human healthcare, animal husbandry and agriculture. A stricter and more coordinated compliance mechanism across the pharmaceutical supply chain is essential to curb indiscriminate over-the-counter sales and irrational fixed-dose combinations.



ISHAN BAKSHI

In recent weeks, the Indian currency has once again come under pressure. While the rupee had recovered after the steep fall in May, it has once again begun to test those levels, ending Friday at 96.53 against the dollar

OVER THE last few weeks, there have been some signs of foreign capital flows trickling back in. In July, foreign portfolio investors have so far poured in \$1.5 billion in the equity markets, reversing the trend of massive capital outflows witnessed in the months before. Last week, the RBI also disclosed that after the measures it had announced to boost capital flows, so far, \$17.4 billion had been mopped up through the FCNR(B) route, and another \$3.3 through other channels. In April and May, net FDI stood at \$6.5 billion, as compared to \$2.4 billion over the same period last year. Not only are gross FDI inflows higher, but so far, repatriation is lower than last year. These are encouraging signs. Yet, at the same time, concerns are also mounting. Fresh headwinds are buffeting the economy.

Global crude oil prices have edged upwards, hitting \$100 as the conflict of West Asia has reignited concerns over energy supplies. With the Houthis in Yemen attacking oil tankers in the Red Sea, the theatre of conflict has also expanded. After the Strait of Hormuz, now cargo movement through the Bab al-Mandab strait is at risk. The renewed conflict comes at a time when oil inventories are depleting. The combination of higher energy costs and possible constraints on supplies will have consequences for India at multiple levels. India's crude oil basket, which had fallen from \$114.48 per barrel in April to \$83.22 in June, has now edged up to \$103.33 per barrel as on July 23. If global crude oil prices are sustained at these levels, the economy will feel the pain. Inflationary pressures will mount. Though whether prices at the pump are raised will depend on the capacity of the oil companies and the government to absorb the price shock. The current account will also come under stress, financing which has been challenging.

In recent weeks, the Indian currency has once again come under pressure. While the rupee had recovered after the steep fall in May, it has once again begun to test those levels, ending Friday at 96.53 against the dollar. The US dollar index — which measures the strength of the green-

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 back against a basket of six currencies — is strengthening. The Indian currency's weakness, however, predates the conflict in West Asia, raising questions over the country's growth prospects.

There is also uncertainty over the monsoon season and El Nino to contend with. Some believe that both kharif and rabi prospects don't seem great this year. A poor crop will have a bearing on food prices. Food inflation is already inching upwards — the consumer food price index stood at 5.32 per cent in June. Price pressures seem to be building up. The next meeting of the RBI's monetary policy committee, scheduled in early August, will shed light on the central bank's expectations of the trajectory of inflation — where food and fuel play a critical role — and interest rates.

And then there is the tariff issue. Last week, the US imposed a 10 per cent tariff on India, following the USTR's Section 301 investigation. India falls in the category of countries like Bangladesh, Canada, Mexico, UK and Malaysia on whom a 10 per cent tariff has been levied. Other countries such as Vietnam, Turkey and Australia face a slightly higher rate of 12.5 per cent. This, however, may not be the end of the country's tariff challenge. US President Donald Trump has also unveiled a phased tariff plan for imported generic medicines — 100 per cent after two years and 200 per cent thereafter. Further, the outcome of another investigation by the United States Trade Representative into excess capacity and production in manufacturing sectors is also awaited. This investigation targets 16 countries including India, China, EU, Mexico, Taiwan and Vietnam. While it remains to be seen whether this investigation also proposes the levy of additional tariffs, it does seem that tariffs will remain an internal part of Trump's economic strategy.

All this makes for a challenging environment, navigating which will require coordinated action and deft handling by policy makers.

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Saudi-US deal exposes alarming contradictions of new world order



MANAV SACHDEVA

THE REPORTED Saudi-American nuclear cooperation agreement (if it lasts Trump's mood swings) represents a geopolitical inflexion point that exposes the fundamental contradictions at the heart of the current international order — the fragility of strategic partnerships, and the hollow nature of values-based foreign policy in an age of competitive great power interests.

On its surface, the deal is straightforward: The United States extends civilian nuclear technology to Saudi Arabia as part of a broader package aimed at normalising Israeli-Saudi relations, consolidating American influence in the Gulf, and offsetting Iranian regional reach. The optics are managed. The Saudis frame it as energy security for a hydrocarbon-dependent economy transitioning toward Vision 2030. The Americans frame it as non-proliferation-compliant, insisting that enrichment and reprocessing restrictions will be embedded in any agreement. Yet the subtext is unmistakable, and it is alarming: This is a pathway toward a nuclear-armed Saudi Arabia, and everyone at the table knows it.

The first casualty of this arrangement is any coherent American non-proliferation strategy. The Iran nuclear deal, painstakingly negotiated under Obama and methodically dismantled under Trump, was predicated on the principle that nuclear proliferation in the Middle East had to be arrested, that Iranian enrichment was the primary threat, and that a rules-based order required consistency. The Saudi agreement obliterates that principle. If the United States is now willing to facilitate nuclear technology transfer to Riyadh in exchange for regional alignment, the message to every aspiring nuclear power is crystalline: Proliferation is negotiable when strategic interest demands it.

This brings us to the second-order question: What does a nuclear-armed Saudi Arabia mean for Iran, and by extension, for the Shia-Sunni sectarian divide that has metastasised across the region?

The Saudi-Iranian rivalry has been the organising principle of Middle Eastern geopolitics for decades. It is sectarian in language and theology, but fundamentally it is about hegemony.

This competition has raged through proxy wars in Syria, Iraq, Yemen, and Lebanon. It has shaped Pakistan's strategic calculus, influenced Gulf monarchies' foreign policies, and roiled Afghanistan.

A nuclear-armed Saudi Arabia fundamentally alters the power dynamic. It removes the Iranian presumption that technological and strategic initiative rests with Tehran. More dangerously, it injects a nuclear dimension

into a sectarian conflict that has proven difficult to manage even in conventional terms. The psychological impact on Iran should not be underestimated. For Tehran, which has invested decades in its nuclear programme as both a shield and a symbol of national dignity and technological prowess, the sight of its Arab rival acquiring nuclear capacity through American largesse will be read as an existential provocation. The likely Iranian response is further acceleration of enrichment, pursuit of weapons capability outside any negotiating framework, and a hardening of revolutionary credentials at home. The sectarian divide, which has shown signs of pragmatic negotiation in certain contexts (the Iraqi political settlement, the Lebanese confessional model), will deepen. We should expect a renewed arms race in asymmetric capabilities, proxy conflicts, and sectarian mobilisation across the region.

The Israel dimension adds another layer of complexity and contradiction. For decades, Saudi Arabia and Israel shared a common enemy in Iran. That symmetry justified quiet cooperation. But now, with a nuclear Saudi Arabia on the horizon, Israel confronts a new version of the problem it has always sought to prevent: A nuclear Middle East that it does not dominate. The Israeli strategic establishment has long operated on the principle that it must maintain a decisive technological and military edge. A nuclear Saudi Arabia, even if theoretically non-threatening in intent, represents a diffusion of this monopoly that Tel Aviv has always found intolerable.

As Saudi nuclear capacity grows, the incentives for Israeli-Saudi cooperation will erode. What appears today as a grand bargain may appear tomorrow as a temporary alignment before deeper structural conflicts reassert themselves. This is particularly true if a future Israeli-Iranian conflict escalates. Will Saudi Arabia remain neutral? Will it defend American interests or its own? The agreement assumes a harmony of interests that history does not support.

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The writer is a diplomat and former United Nations aid worker



ILLUSTRATION: SUVAJIT DEY



SADAF HUSSAIN

To understand closing of the Strait, follow the cook

ANTHONY BOURDAIN wrote that “despite our ridiculously hypocritical attitudes towards immigration, we demand that Mexicans cook a large percentage of the food we eat.” In Delhi, we demand that a man from Kishanganj (Bihar) or Kausani (Uttarakhand) cook a large part of what this city eats, under a name that erases him: Punjabi or Mughlai, anything but Bihari or Pahadi. These are the men to watch now, because the closing of the Strait of Hormuz is doing one thing to them and another to the households at the other end of the class ladder, and the two are moving in opposite directions.

India imports around 60 per cent of its LPG, and until the US and Israel's war with Iran, roughly 90 per cent of those imports came through the Strait of Hormuz. As the war escalated, the government invoked the Essential Commodities Act, stretched the gap between domestic refills from 21 days to 25 to stop people hoarding cylinders, and raised the price of a cylinder by Rs 60 within days.

People who, in normal times, want their food fresh, local and organic, do the opposite under a supply shock. They fill the pantry with tins, packets, the industrially processed food they spend the rest of the year signalling their distance from. Pierre Bourdieu, whose 1984 book, *Distinction*, remains the sharpest thing written

What separated the households that survived from the households that broke was not income. The ones that survived had a plot to return to and a harvest they could eat without paying much for it

on how class hides inside taste, put it flatly: “Taste classifies, and it classifies the classifier”. The organic vegetable and the imported tin are both purchases. What differs is who can afford to stockpile against a war.

Now let's follow the cook again. When the gas that runs his stall or his employer's kitchen stops coming and the work dries up, he does not stockpile. He gets on a train to the village in Bihar because the room in the city costs money he is no longer earning, and because in the village there is family, and there is, sometimes, land.

We like to tell ourselves the cook goes home and eats clean, off his own field, closer to the soil, free of a packet he could never afford. This is mostly false, and we know it, because we watched it five years ago. In the CMIE's household panel, which tracked families through the Covid-19 reverse migration, diets did not improve when the workers went home. They cratered. Eggs, meat, fruit, and vegetables fell hardest. Food spending in the poorest districts never climbed back, even after the economy recovered.

What separated the households that survived from the households that broke was not income. The ones that survived had a plot to return to and a harvest they could eat without paying much for it. That is the fault line

this war is exposing: Not rich against poor, but rooted against rootless.

The behavioural economist Sendhil Mullainathan and psychologist Eldar Shafir wrote in 2013 that scarcity is “having less than you feel you need”. It makes us “tunnel”, which they define as the pull “to focus single-mindedly on managing the scarcity at hand”. The point usually lost is that the tunnel is the same for everyone. Only the exit differs, and the exit is bought with resources.

The worst place to be standing is in the middle. The second-generation urban migrant, the man whose family sold or lost the village land a generation ago, has no plot to retreat to and no pantry to stockpile. He has only the market, at the precise moment a war 3,000 km away has broken it.

For two decades, we cheered as people left the land for wage work in cities. In ordinary times that migration lifted them. But we let the old fallback rot as we did it, the plot, the joint family, the village that could absorb the returning sons and daughters, and we put nothing in the city in its place that holds when a strait closes. Ration shops are open, and they will keep people alive. But staying alive is not the same as eating well. This war has shown us how thin the floor is under the people who cook for everyone else, and how many of them have nowhere left to fall.

Hussain is a chef and author

Trump’s tariff threat on generics: Why it matters for Indian pharma firms

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, July 26

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump on Tuesday (July 21) said that tariffs on generic drugs in the US will be raised 100% after two years and to 200% thereafter to “reshore” generic pharma production in the US, adding that companies deciding against building plants in the US will be “penalised”.

Trump’s threat comes after several such ultimatums, largely designed to attract investment in the US. Actual tariffs on drugs have been exempted in most tariff instruments his administration has used, starting with those under the International Emergency Economic Powers Act, Section 122 of the 1974 Trade Act, and Section 232 of the Trade Expansion Act of 1962.

Here’s why this assumes significance for India and how Indian pharma giants are already changing tack in terms of investments in the US.

Boosting investments in the US

On at least two occasions, Trump had threatened tariffs on medicines despite push-back within the US. On April 2 this year, he announced tariffs of up to 100% on specified branded medicines starting July 31 under the Section 232 framework that invokes national security. On September 25, 2025, he announced plans for a 100% tariff on imported branded and patented medicines, but neither proposal has been implemented yet.

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• PHARMA PUSH

THE US is India’s largest pharma export market, accounting for nearly 40% of exports, with about 90% of shipments comprising generics

SUN PHARMA, India’s largest pharma company, announced the acquisition of US-listed Organon & Co. for \$11.8 bn. This is an Indian pharma company’s largest overseas acquisition to date

Trade and investment experts said that these threats are largely aimed at pushing global pharma giants to boost investments in Washington rather than increasing tariffs on drugs, which could trigger a backlash for the Trump administration, especially weeks before the mid-term elections.

E.

This assumes significance for India as the US is India’s largest market for pharmaceutical exports, accounting for an almost 40% share.

Around 90% of India’s pharmaceutical exports to the US are generics. In 2025, India exported \$9.7 billion worth of pharmaceuticals to the US. The US imported \$213 billion worth of pharmaceutical products in 2025, including \$94.1 billion of finished medicines sold in retail packs — the category that includes generic medicines. Tariff-related uncertainties may have triggered investment outflow from India to the US to secure access to the world’s largest consumer market. Sun Pharmaceutical Industries, India’s

largest pharma company, announced the acquisition of US-listed Organon & Co. for \$11.8 billion. This is an Indian pharmaceutical company’s largest overseas acquisition to date.

Rising outbound investments

The outbound investments for pharma during the ongoing financial year, as per official data, is the highest compared with the last four years combined. As per the Commerce Ministry’s reply to a Lok Sabha question on Tuesday, outbound investment from India to the US stood at \$4.08 billion in FY26, up from \$3.44 billion in FY25 and \$2.44 billion in FY24. Apart from the pharma sector, India’s steel companies are also stepping up investment in the US. Last month, US Ambassador to India, Sergio Gor, said that JSW Steel’s \$500 million investment plans in Ohio and Texas would strengthen the India-US partnership.

A report by the research firm Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) said that several leading Indian drug makers already manufacture in the US. Sun Pharma, Zydus Lifesciences, Lupin, Aurobindo Pharma, Cipla and Dr Reddy’s Laboratories operate US-based manufacturing facilities approved by the country’s Food and Drug Administration. Cipla is expanding production at plants in Massachusetts and New York, while Dr Reddy’s Laboratories is willing to increase US manufacturing if it makes commercial sense, GTRI said.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

CBDT issues crypto asset reporting note aligned with OECD framework

Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, July 26

THE CENTRAL Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) has come out with a 198-page guidance note on crypto-asset reporting obligations in a move that will help in global sharing of information on crypto transactions from next year. The guidance note has been released in line with the crypto asset reporting framework (CARF) outlined by the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) putting greater onus on crypto exchanges for providing transactional information about crypto assets.

The CBDT said that guidance note intends to provide guidance to Reporting Crypto-Asset Service Providers (RCASPs) for compliance with the reporting obligations under section 509 of the Income-tax Act, 2025, and under Rules 241 to 244 and Form 167 of the Income-tax Rules, 2026. However, it pointed out that nothing in the guidance note and FAQs should be construed as affecting the permissibility, or the legitimacy of the transactions in crypto-assets as well as regulation for transactions in crypto-assets.

In the note’s foreword, CBDT

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Chairman Ravi Agrawal said the rapid growth of crypto-assets has brought with it a fresh challenge even as India’s commitment to combating tax evasion and protecting its revenue base has remained steadfast. The note will help RCASPs in understanding and discharging their obligations under the Income-tax Act and Income-tax Rules in a clear and practical manner, he added.

The CARF defines “Crypto-Assets” as “a digital representation of value that relies on a cryptographically secured distributed ledger or a similar technology to validate and secure transactions”, which includes cryptocurrencies, as well as cryptography-based tokens.

The framework is expected to bring tax transparency to the crypto-asset sector as it will impose obligations on a new subset of service providers, RCASPs, which are the service providers collecting and reporting information on transactions of crypto-assets. The CARF requires RCASPs to identify their users and to report on specified transactions, with a view to ensuring the annualised reporting of tax-relevant information concerning certain activities in relation to crypto-assets, the note said.

Once received by tax authorities, the information will be automatically exchanged with the tax authorities of the jurisdiction(s) of residence of the crypto-asset users, pursuant to an international agreement that provides a legal basis for the automatic exchange of such information for tax purposes, the note added.

Experts said though there is no additional filing requirement for taxpayers under this guidance note, the importance of accurate reporting and documentation has increased considerably because the tax authorities will have greater access to transaction-level information. “Taxpayers should continue reporting crypto income in accordance with the existing provisions of the Income-tax Act; maintain proper records of purchases, sales, transfers and wallet movements; preserve exchange statements and supporting documentation; and ensure that the information disclosed in their income-tax return is consistent with the records available with crypto exchanges,” Amit Agarwal, Senior Partner, Nangia & Co LLP said.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Budget has buffers to absorb inflation risks: FM

Bengaluru: Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Sunday said there was no immediate need to revise the budget estimates despite risks from erratic monsoons and higher global oil prices, as the government had set aside sufficient buffers to absorb potential shocks.

Inflation is being driven by both external factors and erratic monsoon conditions, the

finance minister said.

She said *El Niño* was posing challenges for crop irrigation and drinking water availability. Less-than-normal monsoon rainfall could also push up prices, she added.

The government has created sufficient buffers to meet potential fiscal challenges, and Sitharaman does not expect to readjust the budget numbers at this stage. **REUTERS**



CONSULTATION ROOM

DR SK SARIN

DIRECTOR, ILBS, NEW DELHI

Hepatitis B: Only a treat-all policy can save lives

Low cost generics can safely and effectively suppress the virus lifelong

THIRTY SEVEN-YEAR-OLD Anand, an engineer from Begusarai, was admitted to hospital with deep jaundice, liver failure and a small tumour caused by hepatitis B infection. He needed an urgent liver transplantation. Sadly, he was unable to get a donor as his only brother was also found to have the infection. We lost Anand. He received his diagnosis nearly 12 years ago but was never put on treatment as he had no symptoms and his liver function tests (LFT) were normal. His death was a stinging pain for me. A life was lost because of inept policies.

Hepatitis B is a DNA virus that causes chronic but silent viral infection of the liver. In 10 per cent of the infected, hepatitis B can remain silent — show no symptoms — yet cause cirrhosis (scarring of the liver), liver failure and liver cancer. Globally, 1.1 million lives were lost due to the infection in 2024 — 17 per cent more than the numbers in 2015. And, in India, around 29 million people live with the infection. Global estimates show that around 15 to 25 per cent of the infected are likely to die due to delayed diagnosis as well as treatment restrictions as seen in the case of Anand. Only three to five per cent of the infected persons get the antiviral drug.

For decades, hepatitis B treatment has been offered only to those who have a high viral load, raised liver enzymes, or scarring or stiffening of the liver. Unfortunately, seven in 10 infected patients do not get the treatment based on these guidelines.

These restrictions may be valid when the treatment is unaffordable or drug resistance is common. When it comes to India, as the pharmacy of the world, the country supplies generic antivirals globally. Potent low cost (less than Rs 1,000/month), once-daily generics, such as tenofovir and entecavir, which are part of the National Viral Hepatitis Control Programme (NVHCP), can safely and effectively suppress the virus life-long.

The theme of this year's World Hepatitis Day (July 28) is 'Let us break it down'. This is good news for the people living with Hepatitis B. The new Asian guidelines released in June 2026 have made very important recommendations. These recommend treatment at any level of detectable hepatitis B DNA and above normal liver enzyme levels, irrespective of scarring. This, in a way, supports "Treat All" rather than "Treat Select" policy. This is already true for the country's

Every pregnant woman should be screened and those with high hepatitis B DNA should receive antiviral prophylaxis. Every newborn should receive hepatitis B vaccination, preferably within 24 hours

AIDS control programme, which initiates antiretroviral therapy for any detectable level of viral load. The AIDS programme demonstrates that it is possible.

It would be a matter of pride for India if the NVHCP moves towards early viral suppression and cancer prevention. We should not wait for hepatitis B to produce advanced fibrosis, cirrhosis or liver cancer before offering protection. Some fear that patients without symptoms may not take the drugs regularly. This is ill-founded as more than 75 per cent patients adhere to treatment and reach virus undetectable state. Like the HIV, the treatment should not be stopped. Another key issue is the social stigma as hepatitis B is often clubbed with HIV.

Marriages break if the wife tests positive for hepatitis B during pregnancy. Job offers are withdrawn, promotions are denied. Students are excluded. Surgery or dental care are refused. Families isolate individuals who pose no risk through ordinary social contact. This injustice is due to sheer ignorance. In India, a majority of hepatitis B infections are transmitted from mother to baby. The infected child can't choose their mother, they have no choice but to receive and silently carry the virus. Decades later, once detected, the person is deemed as one with moral failing and shamed publicly. This is the reason most relatives of a patient never get tested and treated. Overcoming the stigma is as important as providing treatment.

The Kerala High Court in 2025 held that denial of public employment solely because a candidate had hepatitis B violated Article 14 of the Constitution and is "illegal, unfair and unjustifiable" if the person is otherwise medically fit. India already has an instructive model in the HIV and AIDS Act, 2017. But, does India need a change of mindset or want millions approaching the court for their justified status and rights in the society?

We, at the Institute of Liver and Biliary Sciences, launched a campaign, EMPATHY (Empowering People Against Hepatitis), in 2018 to address stigma through advocacy, behaviour-change communication and patient empowerment. This should become part of national policy. There is also a need to prevent mother-to-child transmission. Every pregnant woman should be screened and those with high hepatitis B DNA should receive antiviral prophylaxis. Every newborn should receive hepatitis B vaccination, preferably within 24 hours. As for the millions already living with chronic infection, antiviral treatment is prevention, of fibrosis, decompensation, liver cancer and premature death. For them the new Asian guidelines open a way to get antiviral medications. Now, general physicians are empowered to diagnose and prescribe antiviral therapy and not refer all patients. India can surely build and showcase the most effective model for elimination of hepatitis B.

With elderly cancer cases rising, India gets 60-plus therapy model

Tata Memorial and cancer centres recommend geriatric assessment for patients over 60

Purnima Sah

AT 72, two cancer patients may appear similar on paper. But one still walks several kilometres every morning, cooks independently and manages his medications without help. The other has diabetes, mild memory problems, has fallen twice in the past year and needs assistance with everyday activities. Yet both receive similar cancer treatment simply because they are the same age although their ability to tolerate surgery or chemotherapy is different. India's first geriatric oncology guidelines say that approach needs to change.

In a first, Indian oncologists and geriatricians have issued comprehensive guidelines recommending that every cancer patient aged 60 years and above undergo a structured geriatric assessment before starting cancer treatment, particularly chemotherapy, to identify age-related vulnerabilities that could influence treatment tolerance and outcomes. Published in the *Journal of Geriatric Oncology*, the recommendations are India's first consensus guidelines on geriatric oncology. They were developed by a multidisciplinary task force led by Tata Memorial Hospital, Mumbai, in collaboration with the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), New Delhi, and several other cancer centres across the country.

Dr Vanita Noronha, lead author of the guideline, professor and medical oncologist at Tata Memorial Hospital, Mumbai, says the recommendations address an important gap in cancer care in India. "Geriatric oncology itself is still under-practised in India and there are very few geriatricians. Most older patients with cancer continue to be evaluated much like younger patients because oncologists have not traditionally been trained to assess them differently," she says.

The recommendations come at a time when the number of older adults with cancer is steadily increasing. According to the guideline, adults aged 60 years and above already account for more than one-third of patients treated at tertiary cancer centres. Community-based cancer registry data suggest the proportion may be as high as 45 per cent, and it is expected to rise further as India's population ages.

What the guidelines say

The recommendations call for every cancer patient aged 60 years and above to undergo a comprehensive geriatric assessment, preferably before chemotherapy begins, with a repeat assessment three months later to identify any decline in

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physical or functional status during treatment. The guidelines further recommend that, wherever available, older adults with cancer should be registered at geriatric oncology clinics, where care is delivered by a multidisciplinary team, comprising geriatricians, medical oncologists, physiotherapists, occupational therapists, dietitians, clinical pharmacologists, psycho-oncologists or psychologists, and social workers.

The assessment should go well beyond routine cancer evaluation and include physical function, nutritional status, co-existing illnesses, risk of falls, inappropriate medications and polypharmacy, cognition, depression, anxiety, chemotherapy-related toxicity, and social support. Where resources are limited, the expert panel recommends that clinicians should, at a minimum, assess physical function, nutrition, comorbidities and chemotherapy toxicity risk before initiating treatment.

So, an otherwise healthy 68-year-old man with early-stage colon cancer may be able to tolerate standard chemotherapy and recover well after surgery. But a 68-year-old woman with the same cancer, who also has diabetes, hypertension, mild kidney disease, poor nutrition and a history of falls, may face a much higher risk of severe treatment-related complications despite being the same age. "While both patients might appear equally eligible for treatment based on their chronological age, a geriatric assessment can identify these underlying vulnerabilities, allowing doctors to modify chemotherapy doses, improve nutrition, optimise existing medical conditions or choose a less intensive treatment plan without compromising outcomes," says Dr Noronha.

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Looking beyond the tumour

Unlike routine cancer evaluations, which primarily focus on the tumour and whether major organs can tolerate treatment, a geriatric assessment provides a much broader understanding of an older patient's health.

"Older patients with cancer are not simply older versions of younger patients. They have several vulnerabilities that are unrelated to the cancer itself but significantly influence how well they tolerate treatment and how they fare overall. As a result, patients may experience greater toxicity from chemotherapy, poorer quality of life and an overall worse treatment experience," Dr Noronha says.

Indigenising a global formula

Dr Noronha, who established the geriatric oncology clinic at Tata Memorial Hospital and later launched a fellowship programme in the specialty, says India needed recommendations tailored to its own patient population rather than relying solely on international guidance. "There are global guidelines from organisations such as the American Society of Clinical Oncology (ASCO) and the International Society of Geriatric Oncology (SIOG), but our patients are different. Indian patients often have lower muscle mass, different literacy levels, social circumstances and support systems. These factors influence treatment decisions, so we needed guidelines relevant to the Indian context," she says.

How guidelines help

Studies have shown that a geriatric assessment may lead to interventions such as improving nutrition before chemotherapy, prescribing supervised strength and balance

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exercises, reviewing medications, or modifying chemotherapy doses and schedules, helping older patients complete treatment more safely and with fewer complications.

If assessment reveals weight loss or malnutrition, patients may be referred to a dietitian, started on high-protein/high-calorie supplements, encouraged to eat small frequent meals and receive aggressive anti-nausea treatment before chemotherapy. Patients with poor mobility or a history of falls may undergo a programme of strength, balance and endurance exercises with a physiotherapist before and during treatment. This can improve their ability to complete chemotherapy and reduce falls. Older adults often take multiple medicines for diabetes, hypertension or heart disease. A pharmacist or geriatrician reviews these medications to stop unnecessary drugs and reduce harmful interactions with chemotherapy.

Rather than giving a standard full-dose combination regimen, clinicians may begin with a reduced dose (for example, a 20 per cent dose reduction), use a single drug instead of two drugs, or space treatments differently, with more frequent monitoring, particularly in patients at intermediate or high risk of toxicity.

Survivor stories

One of the strongest pieces of evidence comes from the GERICO trial in Denmark. Older patients with colorectal cancer underwent a geriatric assessment before chemotherapy. Those with nutritional or physical impairments were referred to dietitians, received structured exercise programmes and had other age-related problems addressed before and during treatment. Compared with standard care, they completed their planned chemotherapy without dose reductions or delays and also reported better mobility and quality of life.

The 2018 ASCO Geriatric Oncology Guideline includes a real clinical case. It describes a 75-year-old man with stage III colon cancer who appeared fit enough for chemotherapy based on routine oncology assessment. However, a comprehensive geriatric assessment revealed hidden vulnerabilities: he had recently suffered multiple falls, required help with managing his medications and finances, lived alone for much of the day, and had mild cognitive impairment that had not been detected during the standard cancer evaluation. Rather than simply proceeding with chemotherapy, the assessment prompted medication support, fall-prevention measures, involvement of his caregiver in treatment planning and a reassessment of chemotherapy toxicity risk before finalising treatment.

Ultimately, the guidelines encourage doctors to look beyond the number of years a patient has lived and instead assess how well they are functioning. "When older adults are treated as individuals rather than numbers, they feel valued and fight the disease better," says Dr Noronha.

CWG's lifting queen

Mirabai Chanu wins third straight CWG gold, but her relationship with the Games has evolved over the 12-year period

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, July 26

WHEN MIRABAI Chanu walked into Glasgow's SEC Arena as a 20-year-old in 2014, the Commonwealth Games felt enormous.

They were her first major multisport Games, and perhaps her first chance to announce that India had another weightlifting star ready to emerge. Every lift carried consequence. Every kilogram mattered. Twelve years later, she leaves the same city and same venue with her fourth consecutive Commonwealth Games medal – and a golden hat-trick. With nobody to challenge her, Mirabai spiced things up by failing to lift in her first attempts in the snatch as well as clean and jerk sections. But once she got her bearings, she continued to rule the 48kg category in the Commonwealth like a monarch.

Her yet another dominant run on Sunday, lifting a total of 190 kg (85kg in snatch and 105kg in clean and jerk) to win the gold medal, completed a remarkable streak unmatched in Indian weightlifting. It also underscored how Mirabai's relationship with the event had fundamentally changed over her four appearances. The competition that once represented the biggest stage of her career has gradually become a carefully managed stop on a much longer journey.

That evolution mirrors her own. In Glasgow in 2014, Mirabai was still introducing herself to the sporting world. Indian weightlifting was searching for its next face after the generation of Karnam Malleswari and Kunjarani Devi, and the soft-spoken Manipuri knew she belonged among the elite. She lifted fearlessly, pushing eventual champion Sanjita Chanu all the way before settling for silver with a total of 170kg.

That medal became the foundation of a Commonwealth Games career that would stretch over more than a decade, surviving changing weight categories, injuries, Olympic cycles and the relentless demands of staying at the top. If Glasgow was about ambition, Gold Coast in 2018 became about redemption. Few athletes have arrived at a Commonwealth Games carry-



Mirabai Chanu lifted 190 kg to win the gold medal (right) Chanu in action during the clean and jerk section. PTI

ing the emotional baggage Mirabai did. Less than two years earlier, she had walked off the Rio Olympic platform without registering a single successful clean and jerk, one of the most painful afternoons of her career. The failure lingered long after the Games ended. Rebuilding her confidence became as important as rebuilding her technique.

By the time she reached Australia, she was the reigning world champion. This time, there was no uncertainty. Mirabai produced one of the most dominant performances in Commonwealth Games history, totalling 196kg for a gold. The improvement from Glasgow was staggering – 26 kilograms added to her total in four years.

At one level, even that commanding victory reflected an athlete still trying to prove something, as every successful lift was a statement that Rio had been an aberration.

By 2022, that need had disappeared.

Between Gold Coast and Birmingham, Mirabai had become an Olympic silver medalist, one of India's biggest sporting icons and arguably the finest weightlifter in the Commonwealth. She no longer needed the Games to establish



her credentials. Her victory was comfortable, almost inevitable. She defended her title with another Games record, lifting a total of 201kg.

Clear priorities

Long before arriving in Glasgow, Mirabai had made her priorities clear. The Commonwealth Games, she admitted, would not receive her absolute focus because the Asian Games remained the real objective. She spoke openly about avoiding unnecessary risks, about resisting the temptation to chase symbolic milestones such as a 90kg snatch, and about preserving her body for Aichi-Nagoya, where the level of competition rises dramatically with the presence of China, North Korea and other Asian powerhouses.

A fourth successive Commonwealth medal, therefore, says less about her dominance

over this field than about her longevity. Across 12 years, the sport has evolved around her. Rivals have emerged and disappeared. Weight categories have been restructured. Injuries have interrupted momentum. Younger challengers have arrived with bigger ambitions and fresher bodies. Yet Mirabai has remained the constant, adapting not only her lifting but also her understanding of where each competition fits within the larger picture.

And today, the larger picture extends far beyond Glasgow. The Asian Games have long remained the missing piece in an otherwise extraordinary collection. Mirabai owns an Olympic silver medal, a world championship title and now three Commonwealth Games gold medals. Yet, an Asian Games podium finish has eluded her, partly because

Rishikanta lifts 264 kg to win silver medal



Rishikanta Singh. PTI

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 26

RISHIKANTA SINGH Channambam won India's second medal, a silver, at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games. The weightlifter heaved a Commonwealth Games record of 121kg in snatch, before lifting 143kg in the clean and jerk to finish second in the men's 60kg event at the SEC Armadillo.

Rishikanta was joined at the top by Malaysia's Mohamad Aniq Bin Kasdan, who also lifted 121kg in the snatch. Rishikanta had lifted 143kg in his first clean and jerk attempt, but failed his subsequent lifts of 148kg and 151kg. Bin Kasdan set a Games record with a total weight of 273 kg (121 in snatch) and (152 in clean and jerk).

Kenya's Joshua Amunga Mboya claimed the bronze medal with a total lift of 260kg (115kg+145kg), edging out Sri Lanka's SDSS Wiriduwasage, who managed 244kg (109kg+135kg).

He became the first male lifter from Manipur to win a medal at CWG 2026.

of injury and partly because the continental field is considerably stronger than anything the Commonwealth can assemble.

In many ways, the Asian Games has become the challenge that the Olympics once represented – a medal that would complete the story rather than merely embellish it.

These Games were a carefully calibrated checkpoint. Every training session, every attempt selection and every kilogram lifted in Glasgow has been planned with Japan in mind. Unlike the eager youngster of 2014, who chased every possible lift because every lift could change her career, today's Mirabai understands that sometimes greatness lies in knowing exactly what not to chase.

Four Commonwealth Games. Four medals. Four very different versions of Mirabai Chanu.